



ALGERIA

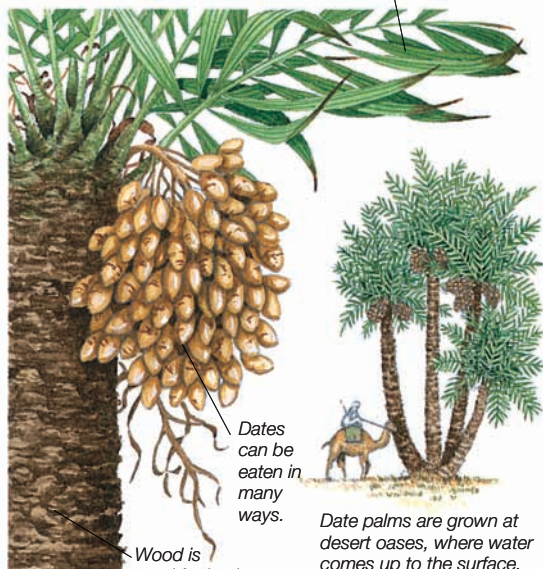
Capital city: Algiers
Area: 919,590 sq miles (2,381,740 sq km)
Population: 31,800,000
Official language: Arabic
Major religions: Muslim 99%, other 1%
Government: Democratic government
Currency: Algerian dinar
Adult literacy rate: 69%
Life expectancy: 71 years
People per doctor: 1,000
Televisions: 105 per 1,000 people

ALGERIA

STRETCHING FROM THE MEDITERRANEAN coast deep into the heart of the Sahara, Algeria is the second largest country in Africa. It won independence from France in 1962, after a bitter, eight-year struggle that claimed one million lives. During French rule, tens of thousands of Europeans arrived, many of them later leaving after independence. Since then, Algeria has played an important part in world affairs as a member of the United Nations and the Arab League. The main challenge facing the democratic government today comes from Islamic fundamentalists who support the setting up of an Islamic government.

The leaves of date palms are used for thatching.

Arabs selling local produce at a market in Ghardaia, Algeria



Date palms are grown at desert oases, where water comes up to the surface.

FARMING

Algeria cannot grow enough crops to feed its rapidly increasing population and has to import about three-quarters of the food it needs. However, about a quarter of the workforce is employed in farming. Major crops include cereals, citrus fruits, grapes, olives, and tobacco. Figs and dates are important, too. Algeria is one of the world's leading producers of dates and of cork, which is made from cork oak bark. Dates are eaten fresh, dried, or ground into flour. Roasted and ground date pits are made into date coffee.

ETHNIC MIX

Almost 32 million people live in Algeria. Although the vast majority of Algerians are Arabs, about a fifth of the population is descended from the earlier Berber settlers. Arabic is the official language and Islam the main religion. Of the million or so Europeans who settled in Algeria before independence, only a few thousand remain. These include people of French, Spanish, and Italian descent.



TERRORIST ATTACKS

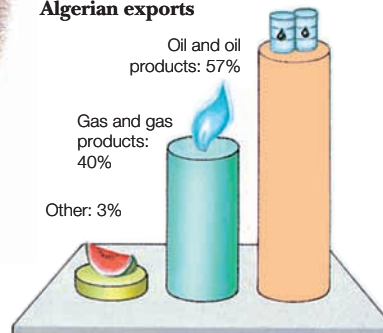
Islamic fundamentalists, like these members of the Islamic Salvation Front (FIS), are in open revolt against Algeria's government. Thousands of Algerians have died in recent years as a result of terrorist violence. Westerners have also been attacked and bombs have been planted in Paris and other French cities.



ALGIERS

Algiers, the capital of Algeria, is the country's largest city and most important port. The city was founded in the 10th century by Muslims from Arabia. It was seized by the Turks in 1518 and by the French in 1830. The French influence can still be seen in these buildings in the modern part of the city along the Bay of Algiers. The old city, with its narrow streets, mosques, and markets, stands on the slopes of the Sahel Hills.

Algerian exports



ECONOMY

Algeria's economy is dependent on its oil and gas reserves. These come from large deposits in the Sahara. Oil production began in 1958. By 1979, it had reached 1.2 million barrels a day. Although falling world oil prices in the 1980s and 1990s caused a drop in oil production, the exploitation of natural gas has since increased. Algeria supplies both France and Italy with gas.

Find out more

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